

The Family Game Book

A book of games for the brothers, the cousins, the backyard, the playground.

For Alexander & Nicolas

Some of these games are old. Some are new. Some need fancy equipment. Most just need an open space and a friend. Tap any game below to read the rules. Then go play.

All the Games

Tap a tile to jump to that game.

LAWN TARGETS



Bocce



Croquet



Cornhole



Ladder Toss



Mölkky



Ring Toss



Horseshoes

TOSS & CATCH



Spikeball



KanJam



Frisbee

NET & COURT



Badminton



Volleyball



Tetherball



Shuffleboard



MINI COURSES



Mini Golf



Disc Golf



PAVEMENT CLASSICS



4 Square



Hopscotch



Jump Rope



Wall Ball



BALL GAMES



Kickball



Wiffle Ball



Spud (Jackpot)



TAG & CHASE



Tag



Hide-and-Seek



Manhunt & CTF



**Ghost in the
Graveyard**



Pool Games

Listen-and-React

⚡ ANYTIME & SPECIALTY



Rock Climbing



Limbo



Settler Games



Road Trip Games



License Plate Game



YOUR GRANDPARENT'S GAMES



Tic-Tac-Toe



Hangman



Peg Game



Dots & Boxes



Jacob's Ladder



Jacks



Pick-Up Sticks



Wood Ball Catcher

The Games

In the order from the tile grid above. Skim, find what you need, then go play.



Bocce

The Italian lawn game

WHAT YOU NEED

8 large balls (4 per team, different colors) + 1 small white "pallino" + flat-ish lawn or sand court

HOW TO PLAY

- A flat patch of yard, gravel, or sand works as a court.
- One team rolls the small **pallino** down the court first.
- That team rolls one bocce ball, trying to get close to the pallino.
- Now the OTHER team rolls — and keeps rolling until they get a ball closer than the first team's.
- When one team gets closer, the OTHER team rolls again.
- After all 8 balls are out: count points. Closest team scores 1 point for EACH of their balls closer than the opponent's closest ball.
- First team to 12 (or 15 or 21 — pick before you start) wins.

 **Pro tip:** You can throw HARD to knock the other team's balls away if you can't get closer. That's a legit move called "knocking" or "spocking."

WATCH & LEARN

▶ Triple S Games: rules in 2 minutes

▶ Backyard rules walkthrough

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Croquet

The garden-party classic

WHAT YOU NEED

6-wicket croquet set (mallets, balls, wire wickets, 2 stakes) + open lawn

HOW TO PLAY

- Set up wickets in the classic 9-wicket pattern (most sets come with a diagram).
- Each player gets a colored mallet and matching ball.
- Hit your ball through the wickets in order, in the right direction.

- You get an EXTRA hit if you knock your ball through a wicket OR hit another player's ball.
- If you hit another player's ball, you can place your ball next to theirs and "send them" with a hit — fun but mean.
- First player to go through all the wickets and hit the final stake wins.



Pro tip: Direction matters more than power. A controlled shot through the next wicket beats a wild blast.

WATCH & LEARN

► [How to play 9-wicket croquet](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)



Cornhole

The backyard BBQ champion

WHAT YOU NEED

2 angled wooden boards with a hole + 8 bean bags (4 per team, 2 colors) + about 30 feet of space

HOW TO PLAY

- Set the two boards 27 feet apart (or closer for kids).
- Two teams, one on each board. Each player gets 4 bags.
- Stand by your board. Toss your bags at the OTHER board.
- Bag IN the hole = **3 points**. Bag on the board = **1 point**.
- After all 8 bags are thrown, do "cancellation scoring": subtract the lower team's score from the higher team's. Only one team scores per round.
- First team to 21 wins (must win by 2). Going OVER 21 = you go back to 15.



Pro tip: A bag that goes IN counts even if it knocks another bag out first. Use this for sneaky comeback shots.

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[▶ Cornhole rules for kids](#)[▶ How to throw a cornhole bag](#)[↑ Back to the top](#)

Ladder Toss (Ladder Ball)

The cabin-and-tailgate favorite

WHAT YOU NEED

Ladder Toss set (2 ladders + 6 bolas — string with 2 balls on each end), 3 per team

HOW TO PLAY

- Set the ladders 15 feet apart (or closer for kids).
- Teams stand at one ladder and throw bolas at the OTHER ladder.
- A bola that wraps around a rung = points. Top rung = **3**. Middle = **2**. Bottom = **1**.
- After everyone throws their 3 bolas, calculate "cancellation scoring": subtract the lower team's score from the higher.
- First team to EXACTLY 21 wins. Going OVER 21 = your score for that round is wiped out.



Pro tip: Throw underhand with a slight upward toss. Aim slightly past the rung — the bola wraps as it falls.

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[▶ Ladder toss rules & tips](#)[↑ Back to the top](#)

Mölkky

The Finnish pin-tossing game

WHAT YOU NEED

12 numbered wooden pins (1-12) + 1 throwing pin (the "Mölkky") + lawn or driveway

HOW TO PLAY

- Set the 12 pins close together about 12 feet from the throwing line.
- Players take turns throwing the Mölkky underhand at the pins.
- Knock down ONE pin = score the NUMBER on that pin.
- Knock down MULTIPLE pins = score the COUNT of pins knocked down (not the numbers).
- After each turn, stand the pins UP exactly where they landed — they spread out over the game.
- First to **exactly 50 points** wins. Go OVER 50 and you drop back to 25.
- Miss 3 turns in a row = you're out.

 **Pro tip:** Early in the game, aim for the high-number pins to build a lead. Near 50, aim very carefully — going over is brutal.

WATCH & LEARN

► [Mölkky rules explained](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Ring Toss

The fair-game classic

WHAT YOU NEED

Ring toss set (a base with pegs + 6+ rope or plastic rings) — or improvise: a stake in the ground + jar rings or hula-hoop chunks

HOW TO PLAY

- Place the peg/stake about 10 feet away (closer for younger kids).

- Each player gets 5 rings per turn.
- Stand behind the line. Toss the rings underhand toward the peg.
- A ring around the peg = **1 point**. (If you have multiple pegs, the farther/smaller pegs = more points.)
- First to 21 wins, or just play "best of 5 rounds."

 **Pro tip:** Gentle underhand toss with a slight arc. Aim slightly PAST the peg — the ring drops onto it as it falls.

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► [Ring toss for kids](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)



Horseshoes

A heavier cousin of ring toss

WHAT YOU NEED

4 metal (or rubber, for kids) horseshoes + 2 stakes pounded into the ground 40 feet apart (less for kids — 20 feet is fine)

HOW TO PLAY

- Set up two stakes, 40 feet apart (or closer for kids).
- Two players or two teams. Each side gets 2 horseshoes.
- Players take turns throwing all of their shoes at the OPPOSITE stake.
- **Ringer** (shoe wraps around the stake) = **3 points**.
- **Leaner** (shoe touching the stake) = **2 points**.
- Closest shoe to the stake (within 6 inches) = **1 point**.
- Only ONE team scores per round (closest shoes). First to 21 wins.

 **Pro tip:** Hold the horseshoe by the curve, not the open ends. A flip in the air helps it wrap around the stake.

WATCH & LEARN

► [Horseshoes rules & pitching](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Spikeball (Roundnet)

The trampoline-net 2v2 game

WHAT YOU NEED

Spikeball set (round mini-trampoline net + small yellow ball) + open space (grass, beach, gym)

HOW TO PLAY

- Set the net flat on the ground. 4 players, 2 teams of 2.
- Players stand around the net. One team serves: spike the ball **DOWN** onto the net so it bounces toward the other team.
- The other team has up to **3 hits** to return — like volleyball: pass, set, spike back onto the net.
- If you miss the net, hit the rim, or hit the ground = **OTHER** team scores.
- There are **NO** sides — players can move around the net once the ball is in play.
- First team to 21 points wins (must win by 2).



Pro tip: On the third hit, **AIM AT THE NET** — angle the spike so it bounces **FAR** from the other team. Pick a spot where they aren't.

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► [Triple S Games: rules in 2 minutes](#)

► [Beginner tips & strategy](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



KanJam

WHAT YOU NEED

2 KanJam plastic cans (with a slot in the front) + 1 frisbee + open space (about 50 feet)

HOW TO PLAY

- Set the two cans 50 feet apart. 4 players, 2 teams of 2.
- One teammate **THROWS** the frisbee from beside their can. The **OTHER** teammate, standing by the **FAR** can, can **REDIRECT** the frisbee with their hands.
- Hit the side of the **OPPOSITE** can (no redirect) = **1 point**. Redirect off teammate into the side = **2 points**. Redirect into the **SLOT** = **INSTANT WIN**.
- Throw goes directly into the slot (no redirect, no teammate hit) = also instant win.
- Teams alternate throws. First to **EXACTLY 21** wins. Going over = back to 11.

 **Pro tip:** For the redirect, use a flat open palm. Tap the frisbee — don't grab it. The slot win is rare and glorious.

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▶ [KanJam rules & tips](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Frisbee (Catch & Ultimate)

The universal flying disc

WHAT YOU NEED

1 disc + open space

HOW TO PLAY

- **Simple catch:** stand 20+ feet apart, throw to each other. Build distance and accuracy.

- **Backhand throw:** hold disc flat, thumb on top. Step toward your target, snap your wrist as you release.
- **Forehand (flick):** hold like a peace sign on the underside. Snap wrist forward and out. Harder to learn — practice patient.
- **Ultimate-lite:** 2 teams. End zones at each end of a field. Catch the disc in the opposing end zone = 1 point. You CAN'T run with the disc — once you catch it, you have to pivot and pass.
- If the disc is dropped, intercepted, or hits the ground = other team takes over.

 **Pro tip:** Look at where you're throwing, not at the disc. Step toward your target. Snap the wrist hard at the end.

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► [How to throw a frisbee](#)

► [Ultimate Frisbee for beginners](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Badminton

The backyard cousin of tennis

WHAT YOU NEED

Net (5 ft high) + 2 racquets + a shuttlecock (also called "birdie") + flat space

HOW TO PLAY

- Set up the net. Singles (1v1) or doubles (2v2).
- Serve from behind the back line, underhand only. Serve must go **DIAGONALLY** into the opponent's box.
- Hit the birdie back and forth over the net. It must **NOT** touch the ground on your side or you lose the point.
- Birdie touches the ground = point for the **OTHER** team.
- You score on **EVERY** rally — whoever wins the rally gets the point.
- First to 21 points wins (must win by 2).

 **Pro tip:** Use your WRIST, not your arm. The birdie is featherlight — small flicks are more accurate than big swings.

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► **Badminton basics for kids**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Volleyball

Bump, set, spike

WHAT YOU NEED

Volleyball + a net (or just a rope between two trees) + open space (grass, beach, sand)

HOW TO PLAY

- Two teams (2v2 is great, 6v6 is real). Net in the middle.
- Serve from behind the back line — hit the ball over the net.
- Once it's in play, each team gets up to **3 hits** to send it back: **BUMP** (forearm pass), **SET** (overhead pop), **SPIKE** (slam over the net).
- Ball hits the ground on your side, or you can't return it = OTHER team scores.
- Score on every rally. First team to 25 points wins (must win by 2).

 **Pro tip:** For the bump: arms straight, hands clasped, hit with the FOREARMS not the wrists. Don't swing — let the ball do the work.

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► **Bump, set, spike for beginners**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Tetherball

The playground 1-on-1

WHAT YOU NEED

Tetherball pole + tetherball (a small ball on a rope attached to the top of the pole)

HOW TO PLAY

- 1-on-1 game. Two players, one on each side of the pole.
- Pick a direction. One player hits the ball IN that direction. The other player tries to hit it BACK in the OPPOSITE direction.
- Goal: wrap the rope ALL the way around the pole in YOUR direction.
- You can hit with hands, fists, or even a forearm.
- NO grabbing the rope. NO touching the pole. NO going under your direction line. Break a rule = the other player wins.



Pro tip: Hit the ball EARLY, while it's still on the high arc moving toward you. Wait too long and your opponent gets the next swing.

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► **Tetherball rules & tips**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Shuffleboard

Slide your way to victory

WHAT YOU NEED

Shuffleboard court (chalk-marked driveway works) OR shuffleboard table + 8 pucks (4 per side, 2 colors)

HOW TO PLAY

- Mark scoring zones at the far end: 10 (back), 8 (middle), 7 (front), and a "10-OFF" trap (penalty zone).

- Players alternate sliding pucks toward the far end.
- Pucks that come to rest in a scoring zone = those points. Pucks in 10-OFF = MINUS 10.
- You can KNOCK opponents off the scoring zones with your own pucks.
- After all 8 pucks are out, tally points. First to 75 (or 100, or whatever you agreed) wins.

 **Pro tip:** Don't always go for the 10 — sometimes a "blocker" puck protecting your other pucks is worth more than risking the 10-OFF.

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► [How to play shuffleboard](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Mini Golf

Putt-putt for the win

WHAT YOU NEED

A mini golf course + putter + ball + scorecard + pencil (usually provided)

HOW TO PLAY

- 18 holes, usually par 3 each.
- Take turns. Whoever scored highest on the LAST hole goes first on the next.
- Putt the ball with as few strokes as possible.
- Ball must come to rest before the next stroke.
- If you take more than 6 strokes on one hole, pick up the ball and write **6** on the scorecard. Move on.
- Total all 18 holes. **Lowest score wins.**

 **Pro tip:** Read the slope. Don't aim where you want the ball to GO — aim where the ball will ROLL FROM. A gentle tap is usually better than a hard one.

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▶ Mini golf tips for kids

↑ Back to the top



Disc Golf

Frisbee meets golf

WHAT YOU NEED

1-3 discs per person (a "driver" for distance, a "putter" for short shots) + a disc golf course (free at many parks)

HOW TO PLAY

- Like real golf — each hole has a tee box and a "basket" (a metal chain catcher).
- Tee off at the start of each hole.
- After your throw, your next throw is from WHERE THE DISC LANDED.
- Keep throwing until the disc lands in the basket.
- Count your throws. **Fewer = better.**
- Each hole has a "par" — the expected number of throws.



Pro tip: For distance: release the disc FLAT, with a snap of the wrist. For control: use a slower disc (putter) even on long shots — you'll lose distance but gain accuracy.

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▶ Disc golf for beginners

↑ Back to the top

4

4 Square

WHAT YOU NEED

Chalk (or 4 floor tiles) + 1 playground ball + 4 players (extras line up to enter)

HOW TO PLAY

- Draw a large square. Divide it into 4 smaller squares. Number them 1-4. Square 1 = "King."
- One player stands in each square. The King (Square 1) starts.
- The King bounces the ball ONCE in their square, then hits it (with hands) into someone else's square.
- That player must let it bounce ONCE in their square, then hit it into someone else's square — and so on.
- You're OUT if: ball bounces twice in your square, you hit it out, or you fail to hit it.
- Out = go to the back of the line. Everyone moves up one square. Next person enters at Square 4.



Pro tip: Hit hard CORNER shots to your opponents — those are hardest to return. The King gets to MAKE UP rules (no-spin, slams, around-the-world) — but only the King.

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▶ 4 Square rules for kids

↑ Back to the top



Hopscotch

The chalk-and-pebble classic

WHAT YOU NEED

Chalk + a small flat marker (stone, beanbag, button) + pavement

HOW TO PLAY

- Draw 10 numbered squares — usually a pattern like 1, 2, 3, 4-5 (side by side), 6, 7-8 (side by side), 9, 10.
- Player 1: toss your marker onto Square 1.
- Hop through the squares, SKIPPING the marker square. Single squares = one foot. Side-by-side squares = both feet.
- At the top (10), turn around and hop back. On the way back, PICK UP the marker as you pass it.
- Successful trip? Toss to Square 2 next time. Then Square 3. All the way to 10.
- You're OUT if: marker misses the square, you step on a line, you put two feet in a single square.



Pro tip: Throw the marker first, THEN hop. Lining up the throw is the hardest part — practice the toss before the hop.

WATCH & LEARN

► [Hopscotch rules & chants](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Jump Rope

Solo, partner, or double-Dutch

WHAT YOU NEED

A jump rope (or 2 long ropes for double-Dutch) + open space

HOW TO PLAY

- **Solo:** hold the rope, swing it over your head, jump when it comes around. Land soft. Count the jumps.
- **Long rope (2 spinners + 1 jumper):** two people swing a long rope in a steady rhythm. A third person jumps inside.
- **Double Dutch:** two ropes, two spinners, one jumper. Ropes turn opposite directions — like an eggbeater. The jumper hops both ropes.
- **Chants:** "Cinderella, dressed in yella..." — counting chants make it more fun.

- **Stop conditions:** if a jumper trips, they're out and a spinner takes over.



Pro tip: For solo: bend your elbows, let the rope spin from your WRISTS not your shoulders. Small hops, not big jumps.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ Jump rope basics for kids](#)[▶ Double Dutch tutorial](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Wall Ball (Butts Up)

The schoolyard wall game

WHAT YOU NEED

1 tennis or rubber ball + a wall + 2+ players

HOW TO PLAY

- One player throws the ball at the wall. It must hit the wall and bounce back.
- Another player must catch it ON THE FLY or after ONE bounce.
- If a player drops it or fails to catch it = they must run and touch the wall before another player can grab the ball and throw it AT the wall again.
- If they don't touch the wall before the ball hits it = they get a strike (or get to be "butts up" against the wall while everyone throws gently at them, depending on house rules).
- 3 strikes = out.



Pro tip: Aim for the corner where the wall meets the ground — bounces become unpredictable.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ Wall ball game rules](#)



Kickball

Baseball, but you kick

WHAT YOU NEED

1 large rubber ball + 4 bases (frisbees, shirts, chalk Xs) + an open field

HOW TO PLAY

- Two teams. One bats (kicks), one fields.
- The pitcher ROLLS the ball to the kicker at home plate.
- The kicker KICKS the rolled ball into the field, then RUNS to first base. As far as they can without being tagged out.
- **You're OUT if:** a fielder catches a kick on the fly, you're tagged with the ball while between bases, or the ball reaches the base before you.
- When 3 outs are recorded, teams SWITCH.
- Innings = both teams bat once. Play 6 innings (or however many).



Pro tip: KICK THROUGH the ball — like a soccer shot — not at it. Power AND placement matter. Aim into a gap.

WATCH & LEARN

▶ [Kickball rules for kids](#)



Wiffle Ball

Backyard baseball, simplified

WHAT YOU NEED

1 Wiffle ball (plastic, with holes) + 1 yellow plastic Wiffle bat + open space (yard, driveway)

HOW TO PLAY

- Just like baseball — but with way fewer players (1v1 works!).
- Set up a "strike zone" against a wall or behind the batter (a chalk square works).
- Pitcher pitches. Batter swings. Hit it in fair territory = on base. Miss 3 = strike out. 4 balls = walk.
- **"Ghost runners"**: with few players, when someone's on base they "live" on that base until the next batter advances them.
- Most yards have "ground rule doubles" and "automatic home runs" based on landmarks. Pick yours before you start.

 **Pro tip:** Wiffle balls CURVE if you hold them with the holes facing one direction. Experiment — the curves get wild.

WATCH & LEARN

▶ [Wiffle Ball backyard rules](#)

▶ [How to throw a Wiffle ball curve](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)



Spud (Jackpot)

The yelling, freezing, throwing game

WHAT YOU NEED

1 ball + 3+ players + open space

HOW TO PLAY

- Each player gets a NUMBER (1, 2, 3...).
- **"It"** tosses the ball straight up and calls out a number.
- EVERYONE runs AWAY from where the ball will land — except the player whose number was called, who runs TOWARD the ball.
- When that player catches the ball, they yell **"SPUD!"** — everyone FREEZES.

- The catcher takes 3 BIG STEPS toward any frozen player, then THROWS the ball at them.
- Hit = that player gets a letter (S, P, U, D). Miss = thrower gets the letter.
- Spell S-P-U-D and you're OUT. Last player standing wins.

 **Pro tip:** Watch which way "It" is looking when they toss the ball. They'll often call the number of someone close — a clue.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ Spud game rules](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)



Tag (and variations)

The eternal game

WHAT YOU NEED

A group of kids + open space

HOW TO PLAY

- **Basic Tag:** one person is "It." Touch (tag) someone — now they're It. Repeat forever.
- **Freeze Tag:** when "It" tags you, you FREEZE in place. Another player can unfreeze you by tagging you back. "It" wins when everyone's frozen.
- **TV Tag:** to avoid being tagged, drop into a crouch and yell the name of a TV show. You can't repeat one. Stay frozen until someone "unfreezes" you with a tag.
- **Shadow Tag:** "It" tags you by stepping on your SHADOW. Sunny days only. Run into the shade for safety.
- **Manhunt-style team tag:** 2 teams. One hides, one seeks. Tagged = sit out the round.

💡 **Pro tip:** In Freeze Tag, designate "safe zones" (the porch, a tree) where you can rest for a count of 10. Otherwise the kids get exhausted.

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▶ **Best tag games for kids**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Hide-and-Seek (+ Sardines)

The all-time classic

WHAT YOU NEED

A house, a yard, or a park + 2+ players

HOW TO PLAY

- **Hide-and-Seek:** one player is "It" and counts to 30 (or 100) with eyes closed. Everyone else hides. "It" searches. Last person found wins.
- When found, you can race "It" back to the counting spot — if you touch base first, you're "safe" for next round.
- **Sardines** (reverse hide-and-seek): ONE person hides; everyone else seeks separately. When you find the hider, you climb in and HIDE WITH them. Last person to find the pile is the next round's hider.
- **Boundaries:** always agree on the area BEFORE starting ("only inside the house," "only this side of the yard").
- **Time limit:** if "It" can't find someone after 5 minutes, call "all-y all-y in come free!" — everyone comes out, round ends.

💡 **Pro tip:** For Sardines, the BEST hiding spots are big enough to hold multiple kids quietly. Pick a closet, a treehouse, or under a porch.

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▶ **Hide-and-seek + Sardines variation**



Manhunt & Capture the Flag

Big-group team chase games

WHAT YOU NEED

A big space (yard, park, woods) + 4+ players + (for CTF) two "flags" — bandanas, towels, sticks

HOW TO PLAY

- **Manhunt:** 2 teams. One hides, one seeks. Once a hider is spotted, the seeker chases. Tagged = you join the seeker team. Last hider standing wins.
- **Capture the Flag:** Divide the play area into 2 sides. Each team plants a "flag" on their side and a "jail" zone too.
- Goal: sneak onto the OTHER team's side, grab their flag, run it back to YOUR side WITHOUT getting tagged.
- Tagged on the other side = go to jail. A teammate can free you by tagging you while you're in jail.
- First team to capture the other's flag wins.



Pro tip: In CTF, put 2 "defenders" by the flag, 2 "rescuers" near the jail, and let the rest attack. Coordinated teams win.

WATCH & LEARN

▶ [Capture the Flag rules](#)

▶ [Manhunt game guide](#)



Ghost in the Graveyard

Hide-and-seek at dusk

WHAT YOU NEED

A yard at dusk or after dark + flashlights (optional) + 3+ players

HOW TO PLAY

- One person is the "Ghost" and hides somewhere in the yard.
- Everyone else stands at "base" (a porch, a tree) and chants: "One o'clock, two o'clock, three o'clock..." up to 12.
- After "12 o'clock", they call: **"MIDNIGHT, I HOPE I DON'T SEE A GHOST TONIGHT!"** and walk into the yard searching.
- When someone SPOTS the Ghost, they YELL **"GHOST IN THE GRAVEYARD!"** and EVERYONE runs back to base.
- The Ghost chases. Whoever the Ghost tags first = the next Ghost.
- If everyone makes it back to base safely, same Ghost hides again.

 **Pro tip:** Best played at twilight. Bring flashlights for after-dark games — but the Ghost stays hidden, no light, until spotted.

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► **Ghost in the Graveyard explained**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Listen-and-React Games

Red Light, Simon Says, Mother May I

WHAT YOU NEED

Open space + 2+ players (more = more fun)

HOW TO PLAY

- **Red Light, Green Light:** one "caller" at the end. "Green light!" = everyone runs toward them. "Red light!" = everyone FREEZES. Caught moving = back to the start. First to touch the caller wins.
- **Simon Says:** caller gives commands. If they say "Simon says [do X]" → do it. If they just say "[do X]" → DON'T do it. Following the wrong command = out.

- **Mother May I?:** players ask "Mother, may I take 3 baby steps?" or "5 giant steps?" The caller answers "yes" or "no" — or makes a counter-offer ("no, but you may take 2 bunny hops"). First to touch the caller wins.

 **Pro tip:** For Simon Says, the trick is to do the moves **WITHOUT** thinking too hard about "Simon says." Listening on autopilot is what trips kids up — slow yourself down on each command.

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► **Red Light, Green Light + Simon Says + Mother May I**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Pool Games

Marco Polo + Sharks & Minnows

WHAT YOU NEED

A pool + 2+ swimmers

HOW TO PLAY

- **Marco Polo:** one player (the "Marco") closes their eyes. They yell "MARCO!" Everyone else has to yell back "POLO!" The Marco tries to tag someone by sound. Whoever they tag is the next Marco.
- No "fish out of water" — you can't leave the pool to escape (or if you do, you become Marco automatically).
- **Sharks & Minnows:** one player ("shark") on one wall. Everyone else ("minnows") on the opposite wall.
- Shark calls "Minnows, swim!" Everyone tries to swim to the **OTHER** wall without being tagged.
- Tagged minnows become sharks. Repeat until one minnow remains.

 **Pro tip:** For Marco Polo, the Marco can yell "FISH OUT OF WATER!" — if any minnow is partly out of the pool when they do, that minnow becomes the next

Marco.

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► **Marco Polo + Sharks & Minnows**

↑ Back to the top



Rock Climbing

Inside, outside, top-rope, bouldering

WHAT YOU NEED

Climbing shoes (rental at any gym), harness (top-rope), chalk bag (optional), helmet (outdoor), and a climbing gym OR an outdoor route + belayer

HOW TO PLAY

- **Bouldering:** no rope, low walls (10–15 ft), padded floor. Climb a route, jump off when done.
- **Top-rope:** a rope is clipped above. You climb, a partner ("belayer") holds the other end and catches you if you fall.
- Routes are graded by difficulty: **V0–V17** for bouldering. **5.0–5.15** for ropes. Higher = harder.
- The **3 points of contact** rule: when reaching for a new hold, keep 3 things (hands and feet) on the wall.
- **Calls for top-rope:** "On belay?" → "Belay on!" → "Climbing!" → "Climb on!" Always check.



Pro tip: Your LEGS do the work, not your arms. Find a foothold FIRST, push up with your legs, then reach with your hand. Arms are for balance — legs are for power.

WATCH & LEARN

► **Rock climbing for kids**

► **Top-rope belays basics**



Limbo

How low can you go?

WHAT YOU NEED

A horizontal stick or pole + 2 people to hold each end (or chair backs) + music (optional but recommended)

HOW TO PLAY

- Two people hold a stick (or broom, or pool noodle) horizontally at chest height.
- Players take turns walking under it, leaning BACKWARD (not forward).
- Don't touch the stick. Don't touch the ground with your hands.
- After everyone goes through, LOWER the stick a few inches.
- Repeat. Eliminated if you fall, touch the stick, or can't make it under.
- Last one in wins.



Pro tip: Lean back from the WAIST, not the knees. Your chest goes under first. Calypso music helps the rhythm.

WATCH & LEARN

▶ [How to limbo](#)



Settler Games

RPS, Thumb War, Mercy

WHAT YOU NEED

Just two hands, two players, and maybe 30 seconds

HOW TO PLAY

- **Rock-Paper-Scissors:** on the count of three, both throw rock (fist), paper (flat hand), or scissors (two fingers). Rock smashes scissors. Scissors cut paper. Paper covers rock. Best of 1, 3, or 5.
- **RPS variations:** "Rock-Paper-Scissors-Lizard-Spock" (5 options). "Roshambo" tournament rounds.
- **Thumb War:** grip hands, thumbs UP. Chant "1, 2, 3, 4, I declare a thumb war!" Try to pin the other person's thumb under yours for 3 seconds.
- **Mercy:** interlace fingers with the other person. Both press down with thumbs and bend each other's wrists. First to yell "MERCY!" loses. (Caution: don't actually hurt each other.)



Pro tip: For RPS: people FALL INTO PATTERNS. If they just won with rock, they're likely to throw paper next (the "winner's rotation"). Use this.

WATCH & LEARN

► **Rock-Paper-Scissors strategy**

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Road Trip Games

For the back seat (License Plate Game has its own section below)

WHAT YOU NEED

A long car ride. That's it.

HOW TO PLAY

- **I Spy:** "I spy with my little eye... something *red*." Others guess until someone gets it. They go next.
- **20 Questions:** one player thinks of a person, place, or thing. Others ask up to 20 YES/NO questions to guess.
- **Slug Bug (Punch Buggy):** see a Volkswagen Beetle = call "Slug bug, [color]!" and (gently) tap your sibling on the shoulder. House rules apply for whether or not actual punches are allowed (we say NO).

- **Alphabet Game:** spot words from billboards/signs that START with each letter — A, then B, then C. First to Z wins.
- **Counting cows / red cars / out-of-state trucks:** pick anything to count. Whoever spots more by the end of the trip wins.
- **The Quiet Game:** the parent classic. Last one to talk wins. Almost never works but always worth a try.

 **Pro tip:** Set a "no negotiation" rule before you start. Whoever calls something FIRST wins it — the back-seat argument over "I saw it first!" can ruin a 4-hour drive.

WATCH & LEARN

► [Best road trip games for kids](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



License Plate Game

Spot all 50 states — and learn geography while you do

WHAT YOU NEED

A printed US map (one shared or one per kid) + an alphabetical list of all 50 states + DC + a pencil or crayon + a long road trip ahead. Keep both in the seat-back pocket so they're always within reach.

HOW TO PLAY

- **The goal:** spot a license plate from every state in the country.
- When you see a new state, CALL IT OUT so everyone knows.
- **Mark it both ways:** cross it off your alphabetical list AND color it in on your map. Both sides matter — the list tells you what's left; the map tells you WHERE.
- Common states (Massachusetts, New York, Connecticut, Rhode Island, New Jersey) fill in fast. Rare states (Hawaii, Alaska, North Dakota, South Dakota, Wyoming) might take a year of trips. Those are the trophy moments.

- **Bonus categories** if you want extra credit: Canadian provinces, territory plates (Puerto Rico, Guam, US Virgin Islands), specialty/vanity plates, government plates, military plates, Mexico plates.

WAYS TO PLAY IT

- **Cooperative (recommended):** everyone helps everyone. The team has spotted Vermont when ANYONE spots Vermont. Less arguing.
- **Competitive:** each kid keeps their own map and list. First to call it out crosses it off. Set a clear "first to call wins" rule before you start.
- **Hard mode:** must spot the states in alphabetical order. Alabama first. Then Alaska. Then Arizona. Brutal but instructive.
- **Long game:** the map and list stay in the car for months. Bring them on every road trip. Coloring in Wyoming six months later is a real moment.

SNEAKY GEOGRAPHY LESSONS

- When a state is spotted, ASK: "Can you find it on the map?" Then: "What states does it border?" Then: "What's its capital?"
- Notice which states share borders — the four corners (Utah, Colorado, Arizona, New Mexico), the Great Lakes states, the Pacific coast.
- Talk about WHY a plate is here — is the driver from there, or visiting? A New Hampshire plate in Massachusetts is normal. A North Dakota plate in Massachusetts is a story.

 **Pro tip:** Some states are nearly impossible to spot in New England without traveling. Hawaii almost never shows up. Make peace with the fact that finishing the list might take years — that's part of the game. The empty squares on your map are reasons to take more trips.

WATCH & LEARN

► [License plate game ideas](#)

► [Teaching kids US geography](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)

Games are how we learn to take turns, lose gracefully, win generously, and trust each other in the silly little ways that make a brother a brother and a friend a friend forever.

YOUR GRANDPARENT'S GAMES

The classics. Pocket-sized, often quiet, no batteries. Many of these go back generations — your great-great-grandparents played versions of them. Most need just paper and a pencil, or a tiny set of pieces you can throw in your bag.



Tic-Tac-Toe

The 3-in-a-row classic

WHAT YOU NEED

Paper + pencil. Or chalk on a sidewalk. Or a stick in the sand. Or just two fingers and a dirty car windshield.

HOW TO PLAY

- Draw a 3-by-3 grid (4 lines — two crossing two).
- One player is **X**, the other is **O**. X always goes first.
- Take turns marking your symbol in any empty square.
- Win by getting THREE of your symbols in a row — across, down, or diagonal.
- If all 9 squares fill up with no winner, it's a "cat's game" — a tie. Start over.



Pro tip: If both players know what they're doing, every game ends in a tie. The fun is in getting tricky — set up TWO ways to win at once so they can only block one.

WATCH & LEARN

► [How to play \(kid-friendly\)](#)

► [Winning strategy](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



Hangman

The word-guessing pencil game

WHAT YOU NEED

Paper + pencil. One person who knows a word, one who doesn't.

HOW TO PLAY

- One player ("the picker") thinks of a word. Don't say it out loud.
- Draw blank dashes on paper — one dash for each letter. (Like _ _ _ _ _ for a 5-letter word.)
- The other player ("the guesser") guesses letters one at a time.
- If the letter IS in the word, the picker writes it in the right blank(s).
- If the letter ISN'T in the word, the picker draws ONE part of the stick figure (or a tree, or a snowman, or anything friendlier). Standard order: head, body, left arm, right arm, left leg, right leg. 6 wrong guesses = the figure is complete and the guesser loses.
- Guesser wins by figuring out the full word before the figure is finished.



Pro tip: Guessers should start with vowels (A, E, I, O, U) — every word usually has at least one. Pickers should pick words with lots of uncommon letters: rhythm, jazzy, fjord, lynx.

WATCH & LEARN

▶ [How to play](#)

↑ [Back to the top](#)



The Peg Game

The triangle puzzle from Cracker Barrel

WHAT YOU NEED

A wooden triangle board with 15 holes and 14 pegs (the famous Cracker Barrel version, or any peg solitaire set).

HOW TO PLAY

- Start with pegs in all holes EXCEPT one (any one of your choosing).
- A "move" = jump one peg over another peg into an empty hole. Just like checkers.
- The peg you jumped OVER gets removed from the board.
- Keep jumping. Each jump removes one peg.
- Goal: end up with ONE peg left on the board. ★
- The board grades you: 1 peg left = "GENIUS." 2 pegs = "PURTY SMART." 3 = "JUST PLAIN DUMB." 4+ = "EGG-NO-RA-MOOSE." (Cracker Barrel's spelling, not ours.)



Pro tip: There's actually a known solution that ends with one peg. The trick: leave the corner empty to start, then plan jumps that don't strand any peg alone.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ Solution walkthrough](#)[▶ How to play](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)



Dots & Boxes

The pencil-and-paper strategy game

WHAT YOU NEED

Paper + pencil. Or print out a dots grid.

HOW TO PLAY

- Make a grid of dots. Start small — 5 dots across by 5 dots down for a quick game. Bigger grid = longer game.
- Players take turns drawing ONE line between two dots that are next to each other (horizontally or vertically — no diagonals).

- When you draw a line that **COMPLETES** the fourth side of a box, you get that box. Write your initial in it.
- When you complete a box, you go **AGAIN**. (This is the whole strategy of the game — chaining completed boxes.)
- When all lines are drawn, count up boxes. Most boxes wins.

 **Pro tip:** Avoid drawing the 3rd side of a box — it gives the next player a free box. Late in the game, sacrifice 2 boxes to force your opponent to give you 4. (This is called "double-crossing.")

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ Rules & basic play](#)[▶ Strategy](#)[↑ Back to the top](#)

Jacob's Ladder

The wooden fidget toy that "flips" forever

WHAT YOU NEED

A Jacob's Ladder toy — six small wooden blocks connected by ribbons. Old, simple, mesmerizing.

HOW TO PLAY

- Hold the top block flat in your palm, ribbons hanging down.
- Tilt it — the block **FLIPS** down. But thanks to the ribbon weaving, it looks like the block has **CASCADED** down the whole ladder.
- It's an optical illusion. Nothing's actually moving except the top block. The illusion comes from how the ribbons criss-cross.
- You can do it back-and-forth all day. Calming. Hypnotic. Great quiet-time toy.

 **Fun fact:** Jacob's ladders have been around for centuries — even mentioned in 1889 American toy catalogs. Your great-grandparents played with these exact blocks.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ How it works](#)[▶ Tricks & how to hold](#)[↑ Back to the top](#)

Jacks

The little metal stars + a tiny bouncy ball

WHAT YOU NEED

A set of 10 metal jacks (the little six-pointed stars) + 1 small rubber bouncy ball.
A hard smooth floor — kitchen tile, hardwood, sidewalk.

HOW TO PLAY

- Sit cross-legged on the floor. Scatter the 10 jacks loosely in front of you.
- Toss the ball up with one hand. While it's in the air, you must pick up **ONE** jack with that **SAME** hand, then catch the ball before it bounces twice. That's "onesies."
- Pick up the next jack the same way. Keep going until all 10 are in your hand.
- Then "twosies" — pick up jacks **TWO** at a time (5 tosses to get them all).
- Then threesies (4 piles), foursies, fivesies, sixies, sevensies, eightsies, ninesies, tensies.
- Miss the ball, fail to pick up the right number, or touch the wrong jack? Turn ends. Pass the ball.
- Hardest level: tensies — pick up **ALL** 10 jacks in one toss.



Pro tip: Use the **LIGHTER** toss — the ball needs more air time, not more bounce. Let it peak and start coming down before you grab.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ How to play](#)[▶ Advanced tricks](#)[↑ Back to the top](#)



Pick-Up Sticks

Also called Mikado — the steady-hand game

WHAT YOU NEED

A set of thin wooden sticks (usually 25-41), color-coded by point value. A flat surface.

HOW TO PLAY

- Hold all the sticks loosely in one hand. Stand them upright on the table.
- Let go — they fall into a tangled pile. That's the start.
- On your turn, pick up ONE stick at a time — but you can't move ANY of the others. The pile has to stay perfectly still.
- If you move even one other stick, your turn is over. Next player goes.
- Each stick has a point value (color-coded — usually black is highest, then red, blue, green, yellow). Keep the sticks you pick up.
- One special "helper stick" (often black or marked) can be used to gently lever other sticks. Pick it up first if you can.
- Game ends when all sticks are picked up. Highest points wins.



Pro tip: Start with sticks at the **EDGE** of the pile — the ones touching the fewest other sticks. Save the tangled middle for the helper stick.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ How to play](#)[▶ Mikado rules](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)



Wood Ball Catcher

Cup-and-ball — the wooden focus toy

WHAT YOU NEED

A wooden ball-catcher toy: a wooden handle with a cup on top and a wooden ball tied to it by a string. Sometimes called "ball-in-cup," "bilboquet," or "kendama" (Japanese version, more elaborate).

HOW TO PLAY

- Hold the handle. The ball dangles below on the string.
- Flick your wrist upward. The ball flies up.
- While it's in the air, position the cup UNDER it.
- Catch the ball in the cup. Smooth, clean, satisfying.
- That's it. Sounds easy. Isn't.

PROGRESSION CHALLENGES

- **Level 1:** Catch the ball in the cup. Once.
- **Level 2:** Catch it 5 times in a row.
- **Level 3:** Catch it 10 times in a row.
- **Level 4 (kendama):** Land the ball on the SPIKE (some versions have a small spike that fits through a hole in the ball).
- **Level 5:** Around-the-world — toss the ball OVER the top, then catch.

 **Pro tip:** The trick is in the KNEES, not the arms. Bend slightly, then straighten as you lift the cup up to MEET the ball. Smooth and small.

WATCH & LEARN

[▶ How to do it](#)[▶ Kendama \(Japanese version\)](#)

[↑ Back to the top](#)

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